Grahan (Children of the Sun)
by
Sarat T. Rao

Rethink April 2020

Mumbai, Present Day

Backdrop:
A junction of crisscrossing highways formed a vast web under which a large slum area had developed – one of the largest in Mumbai. There were 5 levels of highways here. Always innovative, Mumbai's vast populations of nameless, faceless migrants that actually serviced the city and kept it running, had built homes all under and around this web of pillars that support the highways. There were buildings that many of the slum dwellers were rehabilitated to, which were no better than the lightless slums themselves. All these existed under this web of highways and walkways such that very little light percolated down to these residents.

Story:
Mithi is surrounded by darkness. Not just the one around her but inside her as well. Born with a deteriorating eye condition she lost her sight fully by the time she was 13.

At the same time, the city around her was building so much that the flyovers, walkways and bridges connecting buildings had eclipsed the sun. For most of the city not living in high-rises meant a life in dwindling light and ultimately darkness.

When she was 11, she was delighted to see her parents bring home a little brother. The adoption agency - where her parents worked - said this child was left under a bridge. And so he was called Setu.

Mithi had second sight. She got brief flickers of the future. One day when she was 12, she begged her parents to not go on a field trip to educate villages about reproductive health. She had a vision of them - blood all over their faces. And sadly it came true. A rumour had spread about child abductors and the child-friendly couple was seen as a threat. They were beaten to death with stones and iron rods.

Mithi and Setu were adopted by the agency itself. Mithi lost her vision and retreated into a shell. But a friend of her parents taught her to sing and play the flute. He had a small flat in the city and the pair began to live with him. But when he turned out to be creepy in touch and manner, she had to leave with the baby.

For a brief period she played on the street. But no one could hear her in the din of all the construction and traffic and PA systems. Unbeknownst to her, the city had darkened. Her life

was filled with distrust and any act of kindness viewed with suspicion.

In an ironic twist the pervert died and left his small flat to the children. It was equipped with an AC, a small TV with the internet, a fridge and a bed for one. The agency took care of their education till she was 16. Then the management changed and the aid was stopped.

Mithi developed a talent for music. While the boy grew up to have an instinctive talent for electronics. Mithi had also developed an aversion for company and was alone in a crowded place. And no one cared because the city was reduced to survival. She found a job with a small company making meditative music for a city that was soon depleted of peace and silence. This is where she met Gautam, who was the founder of the company. Gautam fell in love with Mithi and wanted to be with her, but Mithi remained wary. They became friends slowly. Unfortunately, the small venture wasn't making any money and Gautam had no choice but to shut it down.

Frustrated by being a constant victim of the harsh vagaries of life, she decided to leave the city with Setu. Move to the only place she knew. The adoption agency on the outskirts. They were happy to have her back but only after three years. Gautam tried to dissuade Mithi saying that he would find a way of supporting all 3 of them but Mithi refused.

In addition to the difficulty of surviving life in the city, she had to think about Setu. The city was so polluted and with Setu's asthma, it was becoming more and more difficult to stay here. If there was one thing that gave her joy, it was the sweet voice of Setu filled with optimism and unbridled curiosity. A voice that was now riddled with grating coughs and a deeply vexing breathlessness. So many had it. Wheezes, coughs, sneezes, weakness from less light. It was a way of life she detested and now the three years were up.

The time had come to leave.

And then after 7 years she had a terrible vision.

It was terrifying - she heard screams and cries for help and sirens and rubble. She didn't know what it was. All she knew was she had to leave.

She was up all night. Packing a bag. She fell asleep on the floor for a few minutes - jolted awake by the vision. She told Setu to stay with her.

But he was on a mission of his own. He was now eight and had friends and had a plan for going to school and studying. What could she say? Don't go out because of a vision?

Setu wanted to see the sunrise. He had never seen the sun rise. There were so many buildings that all he ever saw was bleak sunlight. Mithi had been promising him that one day they would go to the bridge under which Setu was found – the bridge that connected the two big islands of the city. Apparently that was the best place to see the sunrise. The bridge was inaccessible to

them though. Getting there wasn't easy. And every time little Setu asked, "When Mithi Didi?" Mithi would smile patiently and say, "Soon, Setu, soon."

But Setu was running out of patience. He didn't think that Mithi would actually follow through on her promise. Maybe she couldn't. After all they were not children of the sun – those were the children who lived in high-rises. Setu hatched a plan with his friend Jeetu to go to the top level of the flyover and see the Sunrise from there. Jeetu said that his brother had taken him once and he knew the way.

So early morning, pre-dawn, Setu stole away from home while Mithi was still asleep. He took his inhaler along because he knew it was going to be tough for him to climb up to the fifth level of the flyover. With several breaks and Jeetu lending him a hand they made it to the top. But by the time they made it to the fourth level Setu was breathless. He took a few puffs from the inhaler but still found it tough to go on. Setu decided to turn back. Jeetu was upset with him. He told Setu that they were so close – this was not the time to turn back. But Setu was scared. He remembered that he had to take his medicines. Also if Mithi discovered him gone she would be upset and that is the last thing he wanted. Too tired to climb back down alone, Setu looked for and found the elevator that Jeetu had told him about earlier. Luckily he found it and headed down.

The rumble came out of nowhere.

The flyover, constructed with substandard material and poor design, began to crack and finally fell. A domino effect of collapses led to five levels of roads crashing down on top of the slums that had mushroomed underneath, right where Setu and Mithi's home was. It killed many of the slum dwellers while they were sleeping.

Mithi, who had woken up just before and realized Setu was missing, had stepped out to look for him and that was the only reason she was alive. When she heard the rumble she knew at once her vision hadn't lied. Mithi panicked. Where was Setu?

The multi-flyover collapse led to complete chaos.

Now Mithi alone and blind has to look for her brother before it's too late. His condition was getting worse and he had to take a pill every eight hours. Medicines which were now in her hand.

In the chaos Mithi hunts for Setu. Finally someone tells her that they had found Setu's friend Jeetu with some minor injuries and he was sent to the hospital. She finds Jeetu in a hospital and still wincing in pain, he leaves with her to be her eyes as they both search for Setu.

Over the course of that one harrowing day - a day celebrating light - Mithi must overcome her mistrust of people and find a way to Setu.

Setu is stuck underground in a vast network of tunnels and must use his wits to come back up. But he's soon scared and finds that he is not alone. He comes across a subterranean group of

people that has made their livelihood digging tunnels and has constructed their homes there as well. In total darkness.

How does she find him and what does Setu do to stay alive in a dangerous place where he's an outsider and where he can be sold for labour?

EPISODE 1 (Pre-dawn + Dawn)

- Mithi packing bag tells Setu they'll leave today
- Setu meets Jeetu before leaving and they had a plan to see the sun-rise together
- Mithi is sleeping but wakes up with a jolt. She can't find Setu. She panicks and runs out of the house looking for Setu.
- EARTH-SHAKING CRASH! MAYHEM - five levels of roads have crashed and reduced a slum building to rubble - Mithi can't find Setu or Jeetu.
- People helping in pulling out bodies. Even Mithi helps as she's able to hear a moan beneath the rubble - pulls out an old man
- Learns that Setu and Jeetu had gone up to the same flyover that fell. Mithi freaks out.
- Someone tells her that Jeetu has been taken to a hospital.
- Goes to hospital - the bodies are coming in fast. She touches a dead boy's face - it's not Setu
- Finally finds Jeetu - she shouts their names and a nurse tells her to follow her - Jeetu is semi conscious - tells Mithi he saw Setu enter the maintenance lift of the multi-layered road. He was going down and then it all came crashing

EPISODE 2 – (Morning)

- Mithi stays with Jeetu - he loses consciousness and she looks for a nurse - can't find anyone- there's too much chaos - no one can hear her.
- A kind voice lifts her up - Mithi recognises the voice - it's a famous actress who is married to one of the biggest Bollywood stars- Mithi says her friend is unconscious and her brother is missing.
- The doctors rush to the woman saying her husband needs blood immediately B+ve. He was driving on the flyover when it crashed. They need to look for donors - Mihi says she's B+ - the actress is grateful and gets a nurse to look after Jeetu and gets him to the better ward upstairs.
- Mithi gives blood - husband still unconscious and requires an operation - his car was on the highest level - woman thanks Mithi. Mithi is glad she could help and thanks the actress for looking after Jeetu. The actress asks about Setu, eager to help when the husband convulses - beep beep beep - take him to the ICU!
- Everyone exits the room except Mithi and Jeetu - he says he's better now and tells her exactly what happened - he was saved by a few metres - he saw it happening in front of him - he cries for Setu as they had a fight - wipes tears and with resolve tells Mithi he'll help her.

EPISODE 3 – (Morning)

- Setu gains consciousness - he has nothing with him besides a small mouth organ gifted him by Mithi
- He finds the lift has crashed to the lower tunnels of the Metro - and there's a lot of debris and dust - he follows a light and hears an eerie howl that remains undiminished - it's wind from an air-vent - there's a small room - he hears a whisper and someone runs away from him
- Mithi and Jeetu go to the crash site - he shouts for Setu as well - more bodies - no Setu amongst them.
- Watch a news report about the extent of damage - Mithi asks about the lift and learns that it was smashed all the way down.
- Mithi and Jeetu go to the nearest Metro station - shut and guarded- she pleads as her brother is trapped below. They run into Gautam who's frantically volunteering help - since large machines can't reach the lowest level the rubble has to be cleared by human hands - on behalf of Mithi, Gautam fights with the authorities and is taken away in a Police van

EPISODE 4 – (Morning/Noon)

- Setu meets a girl his age who takes him to a system of houses underground carved out of the tunnels like catacombs- the people down there live in total darkness and work there as well - Setu feels claustrophobic and breathes heavily - the girl takes him to an air vent - he recovers and he gives her the mouth organ - first time she smiles and she tells him her name - Aayat -- suddenly a bell sounds and suddenly she freezes and hides Setu
- Mithi and Jeetu need help to go down but no one has an answer - then Jeetu recalls the ladder that Setu and him climbed to the top levels
- They go ahead to another part of the flyover and sure enough there's a lift with a ladder at the back that goes down the shaft
- But there's security everywhere - Mithi recalls that her neighbour works as a ticket seller in the Metro- maybe he can help?
- They go to his house - they learn that he died in the crash - Jeetu breaks into the small flat and they rummage about and find a blue Metro workers jacket which Mithi wears.
- Jeetu manages to go down and comes up reporting that it's too dark - they need a torch or some kind of light - he's about to come up when a guard spots Mithi
- In a tense moment she pretends to be able to see and says she's inspecting the damage - the guard leaves.
- Jeetu comes up and says he'll figure out a light

EPISODE 5 – (Afternoon)

- Mithi tells him she has to go home anyway to get some things - especially Setu's medicine. They go home - her torch doesn't work - Jeetu says he'll figure something out and tells her to wait there.
- Mithi packs some other things in a back-pack like food and water when - she gets a call from Gautam - he needs her help she's the only person he could call - he needs money for bail - (he can't pay online as his phone's been taken away and needs cash - luckily she has the amount) - in the background she can hear a tussle and Gautam shouts and the call is cut

- She leaves a note for Jeetu saying she's going to the police station to bail Gautam .

- Jeetu goes to some boys he knows nearby asking for a torch - they say they'll give him one - it's' a precious thing where they live and so he must pay for it.
- He runs back home and finds the note - he runs to catch up with Mithi.
- Mithi is at the station and is paying the bail but it isn't enough as he hit an officer and now the officer has increased his bail amount - Mithi doesn't have enough - the cop takes her money saying get some more.
- Jeetu catches up with her and he tells her that the torch will cost them something - and then he claps his hands and says he has an idea - they run back home - he takes the batteries from the TV remote and inserts them in the torch - it works! Why didn't they think of this before?! Mithi thanks him profusely for being so helpful

EPISODE 6 (Late Afternoon)

- Underground people are also worried. The crash has covered some of their air vents.
- Setu is panicking. He knows he needs his pill soon. He has to find a way to get out.
- Setu hides as a man comes and collects the kids and takes them somewhere.
- He follows them and finds they're working on a large machine that is boring tunnels - some kids are removing the debris as the machine drills away inch by inch.
- The big man who rounded up the children sits in a corner shouting orders. Aayat stumbles and makes an error - the big man shouts at her and she cries - he's about to hit her when the bell rings.
- Setu runs back to his hiding place - in his hurry the mouth organ slips out of his pocket clanking to the floor. Setu can't find it in the dark tunnel and he can hear the others coming - so he runs and hides - Aayat doesn't come - he hears all the kids go back silently down the tunnel until it's silent again
- Mithi and Jeetu go down.
- Mithi and Jeetu are almost attacked by a pack of hungry dogs but Mithi sings to them and they calm down. Also she gives them some food while singing.
- The big nasty man finds the mouth organ and torments the kids about it - but Setu steps out of his hiding and says it's his.

EPISODE 7 (Evening)

- Setu is taken to another job down a network of tunnels so he's no longer close to where Mithi and Jeetu are.
- The man plays the mouth organ and Mithi can hear it from far -she is overjoyed that Setu is still alive - they head in that direction.
- Setu is having trouble breathing and his new owner takes him to a doctor.
- Doctor gives Setu medicines and another inhaler. He realizes that Setu is not one of the underground children. He tells the man to leave him here and come back for him tomorrow.
- Later Setu overhears the doctor talking to someone saying that he has found a boy here who does not seem to belong here. Setu gets scared and thinks the doctor has some evil plans for him.

- While the doctor is busy with other patients Setu traces out a map of how he's been walking - so while he was walking he kept a count of his steps - that's something he does in the darkness of his place and it's also something he's picked up form his sister.
- He realises after making the map, that he's beneath a particular metro station. He makes plans to escape as soon as possible.

EPISODE 8 – (Late night)

- Mithi and Jeetu come across a bunch of men and women sleeping in the tunnel - it's very dark and when Jeetu shins the light the ghostly faces wince, the kids run away from it.
- Mithi can't see who they are and how they're living but asks about Setu.
- Aayat steps forward and in her broken uneducated tongue says that he was taken - then the mouth organ is heard again and closer and it's a little boy playing it - the other kids are scared of him - he's the big man's son.
- Mithi and Jeetu ask the big man about Setu – he tells them that he has sold Setu to another contractor.
- Mithi and Jeetu go and find the other contractor – he tells them that Setu was unwell so he took him to the doctor and the doctor has kept him in the clinic.
- Mithi gets worried about Setu. She knows he has not had his medicine and his previous inhaler is almost over.
- Mithi and Jeetu reach the doctor but when the doctor looks for Setu, he is nowhere. Setu took advantage of the doctor being busy and just a few minutes before Mithi and Jeetu came he had slipped out.
- Setu has headed back in the direction he came from.
- Setu finds Aayat and asks her for help to get out of here. Aayat tells him that because of the crash above most of the openings are shut right now – only a few narrow air vents remain which is good because Setu is small he can get out of there. She helps him get out.
- Before he leaves, she gives him back his mouth organ. She learnt how to overcome her fear from him and she stole it back for him.

EPISODE 9 - (Midnight to 4 am)

- Mithi and Jeetu also find Aayat but cannot take the same air vent up to get out. They decide to look for the metro entrance.
- Mithi and Jeetu are caught by a guard and she's found out to be impersonating a Metro officer - she is taken to the station
- Jeetu finds a way to connect with the actress who had helped him earlier in the day.
- She learns about what has happened and comes to bail out Mithi and Gautam.
- Setu goes looking for Mithi and finds out that their house is completely gone. He realizes that many people have died. He goes around looking at the temporary triage tents that have been set up. He keeps asking if people have seen Mithi but no one responds to him. Everyone is busy dealing with their own trauma.
- Someone tells him to go to a particular area where all the dead bodies are lying. Maybe Mithi is there.

- Setu is scared but he goes to that area. When he reaches it he can't bear the smell. He catches sight of a body that seems to be dressed similar to Mithi when he last saw her. But the bodies are piled up haphazardly and he can't get closer. Setu breaks down thinking that he has lost Mithi forever.

EPISODE 10 (Pre-dawn + Dawn)

- The actress comes to bail out Mithi and Gautam. Mithi tells her that Setu is still missing. The actress tells Mithi that she will ask the press to put out information about Setu – and make announcements on TV and Radio for him. She also gives Mithi an autographed photos of Sameer Shahjehan since both the boys are such fans of his.
- Mithi thanks her but is forlorn. She and Gautam go back to the slum area thinking that Setu might have come back there. Jeetu is waiting there for Mithi.
- Jeetu tells Mithi that he has been looking for Setu but can't find him
- Meanwhile Setu after the shock of believing Mithi to be dead decides to go to the bridge that Mithi has always promised that she will take him to. It will be a difficult journey for him to get there but he finds a way.
- After hunting for Setu for some time, Mithi suddenly says that she knows where Setu will be. But they need help to get there.
- Mithi, Gautam and Jeetu go back to find the actress and ask her for help to reach the bridge. She calls the authorities and gets them special permission.
- They reach the bridge. It seems to be empty. Mithi can't see – she asks Jeetu and Gautam if he is there. They are heartbroken and don't want to say no.
- Mithi says she knows he is there – she can sense it. Jeetu and Gautam tell her that he is not there – the bridge is empty. They tell her let's go.
- Mithi keeps standing and then slowly starts walking on to the bridge. Now we hear the sounds of a mouth organ. Gautam and Jeetu look at each other in surprise. Setu steps out of the shadows on the bridge on the other side.
- Setu sees Mithi, who is walking towards him, and starts running towards her shouting her name.
- Mithi also starts running. Setu and Mithi have a tearful reunion in the center of the bridge just as the sun breaks through.
- Jeetu shouts – look Setu – Sunrise! They all turn to watch the sun come up!

The END